



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

BOYS OF SUMMER ARE BACK

Lupe Rodriguez, left, Albert Rodriguez and George Serrano watch player introductions as the Dodgers host Detroit on opening day at Dodger Stadium. Go to [latimes.com/sports](#) and The Times' e-edition.

Text messages show how Bass responded in fire's early hours

Mayor communicated with officials from afar, tried to get federal aid

BY JULIA WICK

Inside the U.S. Embassy in Ghana, Mayor Karen Bass was attending a reception with local and foreign dignitaries as her phone began to ping.

The first urgent message came from her deputy chief of staff, Celine Cordero.

It was 6:48 p.m. on Jan. 7 in the African nation and just before 11 a.m. on what would become a catastrophic day in Los Angeles.

"On phone with Chief Crowley now," Cordero wrote from L.A., referencing then-Fire Chief Kristin Crowley, in a group chat that



ERIC THAYER Getty Images

MAYOR Karen Bass in Pacific Palisades with other officials on Jan. 8 after flying for nearly 24 hours.

included Bass and two of her closest aides, Deputy Mayor of Communications Zach Seidl and Chief of Staff Carolyn Webb de Macias. "2 significant fires in city now. She will call you mayor."

Bass was more than 7,500 miles away from Los Angeles and had attended the inauguration of the Ghanaian president earlier that day as part of a Biden administration delegation.

She was set to depart Accra, the Ghanaian capital, in hours, just after the embassy cocktail party ended.

At home in Los Angeles, the winds were vicious.

A fire had ignited high in

[See Mayor, A12]

U.S. probes state law on students' gender privacy

Investigation targets California policy that bars 'forced outing' and shields teachers who support children.

BY HOWARD BLUME

Federal officials have launched an investigation of the California Department of Education for withholding from parents information about changes to their child's gender identity, setting up a showdown between the state and President Trump, with billions of dollars in federal funding potentially at stake.

The investigation, announced Thursday morning by the U.S. Department of Education, takes aim at a California law, signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in July, that prohibits schools from automatically notifying families about student gender-identity changes and shields teachers from retaliation for supporting transgender student rights. Federal officials contend the California law illegally violates the right of parents to receive school records related to their children.

U.S. Department of Education Secretary Linda McMahon said children are best protected when no information is withheld from parents.

"Teachers and school counselors should not be in the business of advising minors entrusted to their care on consequential decisions about their sexual identity and mental health. That responsibility and privilege lies with a parent or trusted loved one," McMahon said in a statement. "It is not only immoral but also potentially in contradiction with federal law for California schools to hide crucial information about a student's well-being from parents and guardians."

The potential penalty is the loss of federal funds overseen by the Education Department. These include \$2.1 billion annually in funding to offset the effects of family poverty and \$1.33 billion to assist in the education of students with disabilities.

State Supt. of Public Instruction Tony Thurmond said Thursday that the California law addressed a pressing concern for vulnerable students.

"Our students must be safe in order to learn," Thurmond said. "I have heard [See Education, A8]"

KENNEDY UNVEILS CUTS AT HEALTH AGENCIES

Thousands of staffers will be shed in a major restructuring. FDA, CDC, NIH are among entities targeted.

BY JENNY JARVIE

Robert F. Kennedy Jr. announced plans Thursday to slash the Department of Health and Human Services, cutting nearly a quarter of its workforce in a major restructuring that will consolidate several departments.

According to the Department of Health, the cuts will save \$1.8 billion annually and — combined with previous downsizing — reduce the employee headcount from 82,000 to 62,000 full-time employees.

Under a restructuring plan, the number of health department divisions will drop from 28 to 15 — including a new Administration for a Healthy America, or AHA. The number of regional offices will drop from 10 to five.

"We aren't just reducing bureaucratic sprawl," the Health secretary said in a statement. "We are realigning the organization with its core mission and our new priorities in reversing the chronic disease epidemic. This Department will do more — a lot more — at a lower cost to the taxpayer."

Many in the national and global health community have been steeling themselves for dramatic change since Kennedy, an opponent of some vaccines and an advocate of stronger food safety, took office vowing radical reform.

The primary target of Kennedy's cuts is the Food and Drug Administration, which works to ensure the safety and efficacy of foods, drugs, medical devices, tobacco and other regulated products. It will cut its workforce by 3,500 full-time employees — a reduction that a health department fact sheet said "will not affect drug, medical device, or food reviewers, nor will it impact inspectors."

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, a vast \$9-billion agency that works to prevent chronic diseases, fight infectious

[See Downsize, A6]

Sundance to leave Utah for Colorado

The film festival selects Boulder over Cincinnati and Salt Lake City as it steers toward a new era.

BY MARK OLSEN

The Sundance Film Festival will move to Boulder, Colo., beginning with the 2027 edition, a transformative change for one of the independent film community's key annual events.

After a vote Wednesday

by the Sundance Institute's board of trustees, the city was chosen over the two other finalists, Cincinnati and Salt Lake City.

"There was overwhelming support for Boulder," Ebs Burnough, Sundance Institute's board chair, said in an interview Thursday morning. "There certainly was robust conversation, but we as a board have been going through this process for about 18 months now, so there's been a lot of consistent conversation and an evolving conversation and evolving process."

[See Sundance, A10]



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DR. NEVILLE Anderson, outside the frame at left, and mother Haley Behnam comfort Iris Behnam, 4, as she's vaccinated against polio and other diseases.

A dilemma for pediatricians

Should they refuse to accept unvaccinated children or keep them in hopes of changing parents' minds?

BY JENNY GOLD

Orange County pediatrician Dr. Eric Ball still feels guilty about the Disneyland measles outbreak of 2014.

At the time, his office allowed children whose parents refused to vaccinate them to still remain as pa-

tients. Many took advantage of the policy, leaving the children in his practice well below the 95% threshold that experts say is needed to achieve herd immunity. In the end, a single measles case at the theme park spread to 145 people across the country; several were part of his practice.

"I was traumatized," Ball said. "I felt that like we didn't do enough as a practice, and I didn't do enough as a pediatrician, to convince families to get vaccinated." Not only were the children of his anti-vaccine parents left vulnerable to the measles, but they had also exposed other chil-

[See Dilemma, A6]

Drug-resistant fungus is spreading

Preying on the sick and old, *Candida auris* is a yeast that can cause life-threatening illness. **NATION, A4**

Gutted home lists for \$39 million

Once owned by Kanye West, Malibu mansion is in the midst of renovation. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Clouds clearing.
L.A. Basin: 69/52. **B6**

Hearing targets PBS and NPR

GOP House members allege liberal bias as they look at funding of public media. **BUSINESS, A9**

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